The Investigation of Dimnah

The king said to the philosopher,[36] "I've listened to your account of how a crafty slanderer skilled at deception sowed so much unwarranted suspicion that he destroyed a friendship and replaced it with hostility. Now tell me how Dimnah defended his behavior to the lion and his entourage, and how the lion eventually changed his mind regarding the ox, became suspicious of Dimnah, and commanded that he be put to a most horrible death. Tell me how the lion learned about his enemy and what defense the latter offered." 5.1

The philosopher replied: The accounts tell us that after killing the ox, the lion regretted his haste. He remembered the ox's companionship and inviolability as a guest, and, to dispel some of his sadness and grief, he spent long evenings conversing with his companions. The lion's entourage included a leopard who, as one of the lion's most esteemed and distinguished companions, enjoyed access to the lion by day and by night. One evening after the ox's death, the leopard kept the lion company late into the night, before heading home. When he passed by the home of Kalīlah and Dimnah—they lived together in the same house—he overheard Kalīlah rebuking Dimnah for his treachery and deceit. Kalīlah was reminding Dimnah of how he had tried to restrain him and how Dimnah had rejected his advice. The leopard overheard the whole conversation. 5.2

Among other things, Kalīlah said, "You've done a terrible thing, an ugly thing, an appalling act of faithlessness. The consequences of your dreadful betrayal of the lion will soon bring about your downfall. When everything comes out, not one animal will defend your conduct or come to your aid. They will unite one and all to destroy you. For my part, I no longer want to associate with you or be your partner." 5.3

"What's done can't be undone," replied Dimnah. "Brother, don't cause the two of us any more grief. Try to dispel the effect the affair has had on the lion's mood. Rest assured, I'm not going to praise what I did: greed and envy drove me to it."

After hearing their words, the leopard went back and paid a visit to the lion's mother. After making her promise to reveal nothing, he told her what he had heard Kalīlah say and what Dimnah had confessed. The next morning, the lion's mother went to visit the lion. She found him sad and dejected over his thoughtless treatment of the ox. 5.4

"What is making you sad?" she asked.

"The death of the ox," he replied. "I keep thinking of his companionship and devotion, and how I benefited from his opinions and trusted his counsel and advice."

"A man's conscience is the most convincing witness against him," she said. "As your words indicate, your own heart testifies that you attacked the ox before you knew the truth about the matter. Haste is the root of error. When you received the report about the ox, had you restrained yourself, controlled your temper, and compared the report carefully with what you felt in your heart, your heart would have provided sufficient evidence regarding the report's truth or falsity. Hearts reflect each other; therefore, judge how things stood between you and the ox during his lifetime by what you feel about him now after his death."

"Since killing the ox," the lion said, "I've thought and thought, trying to discover even one offense of his that ever excited my anger to confirm my suspicions; but the more I think, the better my opinion of him becomes. I can't recall any viciousness in his character that might have led to his envying me, or any hatred that might have caused him to try to overthrow me, and I see nothing on my part that might have provoked him. I want to investigate the case thoroughly, although I know it won't undo my thoughtlessness; I want to know where I stand regarding the right or wrong of what I did. Tell me, have you heard anything?" 5.5

"I've been told something that I've been asked to conceal," replied the lion's mother. "I would tell you, were it not for what the sages have said about the shamefulness of revealing secrets."

"The sayings of the sages are ambiguous and can be taken in many ways," 5.6
responded the lion. "In some circumstances the reasonable thing is to act on them; in other circumstances to refrain from doing so. The sages have said that covering up and hiding the doings of suspicious people is in itself suspicious, a kind of wrongdoing. Perhaps your informant acquitted himself of a responsibility by passing on the information; therefore, you too should help him by doing what is incumbent on you. He acquitted himself of his obligation to you by informing you; he removed the burden from his neck and put it around yours. Therefore, you too should remove it from your neck by explaining it to me, so we can do what we ought to do in a case like this."

The lion's mother said, "I know that what you say is true, but I also know 5.7
that revealing the secret and burdening you with it would harm me in two ways. First, the person who told me the secret would hate me: he would take it as a betrayal of trust and ascribe it to weakness of character. Second, no one else would trust me with a secret after that."

"I understand," said the lion. "I don't want to look for a way out of my mistake by involving you in a betrayal of trust. If you're unwilling to divulge the informant's name and the details of what he told you, tell me about it in general terms."

She told him all about the conversation. Then she said, "I know very well that the sages have exalted the virtue of pardoning offenders, but that applies only to offenses less serious than the betrayal of the whole community or the betrayal of kings. Fools plead with this saying to excuse their evil deeds. But failing to punish those who deserve punishment will corrupt the entire community. Do not, therefore, allow this traitor, this sower of corruption, to live."

The lion summoned his main companions, who were ushered into his 5.8
presence. Then he summoned Dimnah. Dimnah stood before him and saw from the demeanor of the lion and his companions that something was wrong. Turning to someone next to him, he asked quietly, "Has anything happened to make the king so sad? Has he summoned this gathering because something has happened?"

The lion's mother heard him. "What saddens the king is that he left you alive after seeing how you deceived him and incited him against his loyal adviser. He shouldn't allow you to remain alive a moment longer."

"What has changed his attitude toward me?" asked Dimnah.

"Your machinations," the king's mother answered. "Now he clearly sees how your lies incited him against Shanzabah."

"I think," said Dimnah, "that the first speaker has left nothing for anyone else to say about the ironies of fate. As the saying goes, he who tries hardest to fend off the evils that men do is most likely to become the victim of evil. May this saying not apply to the king and his soldiers! I know the saying was only about associating with evil men: that no amount of wariness will save from their evil someone who knowingly associates with them. That is why ascetics have sequestered themselves and chosen solitude instead of human company, electing to work for God rather than for His creatures, for only God rewards good with good. Most people in this world don't act justly or reward each person as he deserves; indeed, they often inflict on the innocent punishment befitting sinners. But who is more likely to hit the mark than a king who flatters no one out of need and punishes no one out of fear? **5.9**

"The virtue to which kings should most aspire is to reward those who do good service; and what service has been more conspicuously good than my advice? The king, and everyone here, knows there was nothing between me and Shanzabah to cause me to hold a grudge against him or seek his ruin. I had nothing to gain or lose. I advised the king and let him know what I had learned about Shanzabah. In the end, what he saw with his own eyes confirmed what I told him, and as a result he became more decisive and resolute in his judgment. I know that more than one scheming enemy of the king is afraid of me for the same reason, and so they've become my foes and have decided to destroy me. I never expected that the king's sorrow at letting me live would be my reward for sincere advice and good service." **5.10**

When the lion heard Dimnah's words, he ordered him taken to the judge. 5.11
"Investigate his case. I don't want to judge the right or wrong of any action without clearly establishing the truth and justice of it."

"Your Majesty," said the judge, "nothing can dispel blindness, clarify doubt, and uncover obscurities better than a rigorous, thorough investigation."

And Dimnah added, "Your Majesty shouldn't hasten to kill me on the 5.12
word of a slanderer. Let him investigate the matter. The more he considers my case, the more certain he will be of my innocence and loyalty. As Your Majesty knows, fire dwells in trees and rocks; only through labor and effort can it be brought out and put to use. If I were a criminal, I would be as fearful of exposure as, knowing my innocence, I am now hopeful that the investigation will bring out the truth, just as perfumes diffuse their sweetness more widely when stirred. I would have found somewhere else to go if I were conscious of any crime or guilt; I wouldn't have stayed at the king's gate waiting for a reward. If he is in any doubt about me, I ask him to investigate. Let him entrust the matter to someone God-fearing and trustworthy, someone not swayed by slander, neither lenient nor arbitrary, for I held a position that others envied. Instruct that person to investigate and submit a daily report on what he finds out about my case and on the evidence I present. Let the king exercise his judgment, compare one part of the testimony with the other, and not hasten to act on the basis of dubious claims made by malicious and hostile people. If he doesn't do this and instead countenances something unlawful, then I have no helper or refuge but the One who knows the hidden thoughts and hearts of His servants. As the sages have said: If you believe what deserves to be doubted, and reject what deserves to be believed, you risk suffering the fate of the woman who in her confusion gave herself to her servant, who subsequently disgraced her."

"And what was her fate?" asked the lion.

And Dimnah told the following tale: They say that in a certain city there 5.13
lived a merchant whose wife was endowed with both beauty and wealth. *The Wife and Her Lover the Painter*
Next door lived a skilled painter who was the wife's lover. She said to him, "It would make things easier for us if you could devise something to alert me

to your arrival when you come at night, without calling out, throwing something, or arousing suspicion."

"I have just the thing," said the painter, "a coat painted with fantastic images, some white as heart of palm and some jet black, brightly gleaming. Its whiteness will summon you on a dark night, and its blackness will stand out on a moonlit night. I'll wear it when I want to come to you. When you see it, know that it's your special friend and come to me without any summons."

5.14 He wore the coat whenever he came to visit the woman; she knew he was there, admired his skill and delighted in it, and he could visit whenever he wanted. One of the merchant's servants realized what was happening. A few days later, the servant—who happened to be the painter's maidservant's lover—asked the maidservant to lend him the painted coat to show a friend of his, after which he would return it immediately. She gave it to him, and he put it on and visited the merchant's wife in the painter's guise. When she saw him, she had no idea it wasn't her lover and gave herself to him. He satisfied his lust and returned the coat to the maidservant, who put it back in its place.

5.15 The painter had been away, but he came home later that night, donned the coat, and went to visit the woman. When she saw the coat, she came to him. "Why," she asked, "have you returned so soon after satisfying your desire?" The painter returned home in disgust, summoned his maidservant, and threatened to beat her, whereupon she told him the whole story. So the painter burned the coat.

5.16 Dimnah said, "I've told you this story to show you that sowing confusion is as bad as lying. Your Majesty—praise God—is unsurpassed in judgment, great in forbearance, and experienced in affairs. Despite the confusion that's being sown, you saw clear evidence of the ox's hostility and this justified killing him. This should prevent Your Majesty from putting me to death, for you know how sincerely I advised you and protected you from your ministers. Furthermore, Your Majesty knows how I regard my harsh life and meager fortune. You know that I cannot raise my rank above that of a servant and that I don't aspire to what those above me aspire. Though I may be insignificant in the king's eyes, I hope to be granted a portion of his justice in my lifetime and after my death. Death is of little importance to me. I would

even welcome it if I knew that the king would find comfort, joy, and relief after killing me. The sages have said that a sinner who delivers himself up to death to protect the righteous will be pardoned on the Day of Judgment and escape everlasting suffering in the hereafter. Someone as contemptible as I, marked with the stigma of servitude, ought to give up his life for the benefit of a great, God-fearing king like you. He ought to prefer punishment in this world to punishment in the hereafter."

5.17 One of the king's attendants said, "Your Majesty, Dimnah isn't speaking out of reverence or respect for the king, but to escape the consequences of his mischief."

Dimnah replied, "Who will preserve my soul if I neglect it? Who will raise it up if I demean it? Have I any other soul to protect from perdition? Someone who doesn't protect his own life will never protect the lives of his kin. Don't you know there is nothing shameful in seeking to vindicate oneself? I've become the victim of your uncontrolled envy, evil, hatred, and hostility. Someone like you isn't fit to stand at the king's gate, let alone to know him. You shouldn't even keep company with his riding animals."

5.18 The lion's mother said to Dimnah, "I'm amazed less by your previous faithlessness, deception, and corruption than I am by your preaching and reciting parables to those speaking about you."

"This," replied Dimnah, "is the place for preaching, if people would only accept it, and for parables, if people would only heed them."

"Sinful traitor," replied the lion's mother. "If you had any intelligence, you'd be too concerned about what you've laid up for yourself to busy yourself reciting parables."

"A traitor," replied Dimnah, "is someone who is given advice that enables him to triumph over his enemy and then shows no gratitude or joy; a traitor is someone who promises his enemy safety, but kills him though he has committed no misdeed when he gets his hands on him; and is someone who turns against the very person who revealed his enemies' hostility."

5.19 The lion's mother said, "Sinful traitor, you expect your devil to help you argue with lies."

"A liar," replied Dimnah, "is someone who repays benevolence with malice, good with evil, and trust with fear. As for me, I've kept my promise and honored my oath."

"And what," asked the lion's mother, "is this promise you've kept and oath you've honored?"

"The king knows that if I were a liar I wouldn't have spoken these words in his presence about the imposters in his entourage," replied Dimnah.

5.20 The lion's mother saw that the lion hadn't replied to any of Dimnah's arguments, so she began worrying that he might be swayed by some of his excuses and protestations of innocence. She gave voice to her misgivings: "Silence in the face of an opponent's arguments is like conceding the truth of his words. As the sages have said, to keep silent is to agree." And she left.

The lion commanded that Dimnah be made to post bond and be brought before the judge for investigation of his case.

5.21 Later, the lion's mother returned to the lion and said, "I've been hearing for a long time about Dimnah's deceit and corruption. Now his prolific lies, trumped-up excuses, and specious evasions have only confirmed this in my mind. If you give him a chance to speak, he will defend himself with lies and confusing arguments. Killing him will be a great relief to you and your soldiers. Kill him immediately! Don't be swayed by leniency or halted by doubt."

"Courtiers," replied the lion to his mother, "often compete among themselves for positions; envy and malice often develop among them, directed especially at judicious and intelligent colleagues. I know that Dimnah's position vexed more than one of my soldiers and my household. That might be the reason they're uniting against him, as I can well see and hear. So I don't want to act hastily in his case. A precious resource should be consumed only for a good reason and when one is clearly justified in doing so."

The judge ordered that Dimnah be sent to prison, and he was heavily shackled.

5.22 Because of their long companionship and close friendship, Kalīlah felt pity and a sense of responsibility, so he went to visit Dimnah secretly in prison. When he saw Dimnah's distress and wretched state, he wept. "Your condition," he said, "makes admonition unnecessary. But I must remind

you of how I carried out my duty to give you advice and direction, for every utterance has its place. Had I failed to reprimand you when you needed it while all was going well, I would share your guilt today. But conceit took hold of you: it overcame you and confounded your judgment. I often cited the sages' maxim: 'The crafty man dies before his time.' By 'dies before his time,' they didn't mean that his life would end, but that he would suffer the things that ruin life, such as your present troubles, from which death would be a relief."

5.23 Dimnah said, "From our first acquaintance, you've always taken pains to speak the truth. Fulfilling your brotherly obligation, you reproved me and advised me, but greed and ambition ruined me and kept me from taking your advice. I was like a sick man who craves food that he knows will harm him, but disregards that knowledge and surrenders to his appetite. I knew that I had sowed the seeds of trouble for myself and that, no matter how long ago they were planted, they would sprout in time—and the time has come for them to sprout. What torments me even more is my fear for you: that, because of our relationship, you might be suspected in my case and even tortured to make you confess anything I told you about my project. For me, that would be like dying twice, the harsh treatment you would receive being a kind of dying, for no one would doubt the truth of your words about others who have no ties to you, let alone about someone as close to you as I am."

5.24 "I understand what you're saying," said Kalīlah. "The wise have said that our bodies can't bear pain and won't hesitate to say anything, true or false, to avoid it. But I think you should repent of your sin and confess your wrongdoing, since you've been brought to this state. By repenting, you'll free yourself from the consequences in the hereafter. You're going to perish in any case. Don't add perdition in the hereafter to perdition in the here and now."

"You've given sound advice," answered Dimnah. "I'll ponder it and repay you for it."

Filled with grief, distress, and fear, Kalīlah wandered away aimlessly.

Nearby in the prison was another animal, who heard everything that had passed between Kalīlah and Dimnah. He committed it to memory, but kept it to himself.

When Dimnah learned of Kalīlah's flight, he wept for a long time in sorrow for him and in sadness at his departure. "What use is life to me, now that Kalīlah, my good brother and loyal friend, has left me? I see how true the saying is: When Fortune turns against someone in his afflictions and he sinks as low as once he was high, evil attacks him from every side; sadness and grief encompass him, and he is crushed by woes wherever he looks. Fate pursues him, however much he may guard himself against it. No sooner does one misfortune depart than another strikes, and he falls, just as I have fallen victim to this blow. I have lost my comrades, my friends have abandoned me, and now I grieve for the loss of my brother. Misfortune has descended on me in the prime of life, in my days of vigor and the freshness of youth. Kalīlah, my brother and best friend, has departed from me in sadness and sorrow." 5.25

The lion's mother again brought up Dimnah and his betrayal of the lion. "Sparing sinners," she said, "is as bad as killing the innocent. Whoever spares a sinner's life becomes a partner in his sinfulness; whoever spares an innocent's life becomes a partner in his good deeds." 5.26

So the lion commanded the judge to investigate Dimnah's case without delay. He was to submit a report of every argument Dimnah used and every exculpation he presented. The judge put Dimnah on the stand in front of the dignitaries, and he informed the common people of the king's orders to investigate Dimnah's case; to seek out any knowledge that anyone, high or low, had of his actions; to ask Dimnah for his defense, if he had any; and to pass a just judgment. Dimnah would not be allowed to deceive the king or prevent the ruler from reaching a true judgment and obtaining whatever was necessary to vindicate it.

The judge addressed the court: "Let any of you who knows anything about Dimnah's case speak—and that for three reasons: first, to uphold justice and to provide true evidence, however it may fall; second, to enable verdicts to be pronounced that punish offenders, encourage the righteous, and protect the state from evildoers and the offspring of evildoers; and third, to free us from people of malice and deception and to prevent them from harming nobles and commoners alike." 5.27

Everyone remained silent. No one said a word, for they knew nothing certain about the case and were reluctant to give voice to suspicions.

5.28 When Dimnah saw their silence, he spoke up: "If I were a criminal, I would welcome your silence. But I am innocent. Either you know it, or you know of no offense on my part—and anyone not known to have committed an offense cannot be called to account and is innocent. Therefore, you must say about me what you know. But anyone who speaks should realize that words have consequences, whether immediate or delayed. What he says about me will determine whether I live or die. Anyone who without knowledge condemns me to destruction or speaks about me merely on the basis of suspicion will suffer the fate of the physician who pretended to know something about which he really knew nothing."

"And what was his fate?" asked the judge.

5.29 *The Quack Physician Who Claimed Knowledge*

Dimnah told the following tale: In a certain city there lived a learned physician who prospered because of the providential cures that occurred at his hands through his treatments and drugs. In time, this physician grew old and lost his sight. In the same city lived a fool who claimed to know the science of medicine and whose reputation spread among the people. The king of that city had a daughter whom he married to a nephew. She became pregnant and began to feel some of the pains that women experience in pregnancy, so the king sent for the blind physician. He arrived and questioned the young woman's family about her pains. They told him, and he prescribed a well-known medicine, which he named. However, when the king commanded him to compound some of it, he said, "Because I can't see, I can't gather the ingredients as I know they should be, and I don't trust anyone else to gather them." Then the quack came and told them that he was familiar with the medicine's ingredients and their preparation. The king ordered that he be admitted to the storeroom to take what he needed. When the ingredients for medicines were presented to him, he proceeded arbitrarily according to his pretentions, and chose ingredients with neither knowledge nor experience, merely using guesswork and conjecture. One of the things he chose was a bag of deadly poison. He mixed it in with the ingredients and gave it to the young woman to drink. She died within the hour. The king summoned the quack and made him drink some of the medicine he had prepared. He died on the spot.

At that point someone spoke up: "Scholars and nobles, hearken to my words and ponder them with your understanding, your fullest intelligence, and your most diligent judgment. Scholars have said that the righteous can be known by means of certain things which they have described, written down, and revealed. Thanks to God's kindness and favor toward you in perfecting your intelligence, you learned men know the righteous by their distinguishing features and need no more than the merest indications. This wretch, on whom are visible the signs of evil and marks of sinfulness spelled out by the sages, is someone whose wickedness is beyond question for ordinary people and whose case is unequivocal for the elite." 5.30

"What are those marks and signs?" asked the judge. "You know more about them than we do." 5.31

And the speaker explained:[37] "They are as we read in scholarly books: Anyone whose left eye is smaller than his right, whose eye blinks constantly, whose nose bends to the right, who has a wide space between his eyebrows, whose body hairs grow in threes, who looks mostly at the ground as he walks and repeatedly looks back—in such a person treachery and wrongful conduct toward the righteous coalesce. All these signs are present in Dimnah."

Dimnah responded: "God's judgment upon His creatures is just and contains no injustice; it is true and contains no error. Rulers and judges who seek the truth would need no further evidence or argument if justice could be attained by means of such signs as you have mentioned. No one could be praised for doing good or blamed for doing evil, for no one could change any of the signs that determine his actions. Benefactors could be rewarded, and malefactors punished, merely on the basis of these signs. And if—God protect me!—I did what I am being slandered for based on these signs, then it was those signs that God decreed; there was no way I could have resisted what you have attributed to me and accused me of doing. Another indication of your ignorance of how to pass judgment is that, if what you said were true, my mere possession of these signs would entail no legal consequences for me; for such signs are created with their possessor at the moment of his creation, and born with him at the moment of his birth. Their operations have 5.32

no fixed date: no day or age at which they come into force or when judgment should be passed on those who possess them. And what about those who possess these signs but haven't reached the age of reason? This proves to intelligent people that you are an ignorant fool. You've heard something whose import you didn't understand, and you've applied it wrongly. You are no more learned or intelligent than those present, nor the most qualified to speak. You've spoken in error. What the man said to his wife applies to you: 'First cover your own nakedness, then ask others to cover theirs.'"

"And how did that happen?" asked the judge.

5.33

The Plowman and His Two Wives

Dimnah told the following tale: A city called Burdjird was attacked by an enemy that killed some of its inhabitants and led others away as captives. As his share of the spoils, one of the victors received a plowman and his two wives. As their master, he gave them little to eat and drink and little to wear. One day, the plowman and his naked wives went out to gather firewood. One of the wives found an old rag in the field and covered her private parts. The other wife said to her husband, "Look at that hussy walking around naked!" And her husband replied, "A plague on you! Look at yourself! You are completely naked, yet you find fault and speak evil of someone who has covered her own nakedness. Unbelievable!"

Everyone fell silent when they heard how well Dimnah had replied to his accuser and saw the strength of his arguments. The judge ordered him returned to prison.

5.34

The next morning, the judge went before the lion with a group of dignitaries who had been present at the trial. The judge submitted a written account of the arguments that Dimnah had presented in his defense. The lion took the document and ordered them to leave. He then sent for his mother and read the document to her. Distressed to see that the lion was sympathetic to Dimnah, she said, "Don't be angry if I speak bluntly."

"Go ahead," replied the lion. "Say what you want to say."

"I don't think you can distinguish what harms you from what benefits you," she said. "By dragging things out so long, Dimnah is going to stir up so much discord that you won't be able to contain it." And with these words she left in anger.

The next morning, the judge sent for Dimnah and made him stand before the full assembly. When no one ventured to say anything, the judge himself addressed Dimnah: "Although everyone here has kept silent and said nothing against you, they all suspect you are a criminal. Now that the charge against you has taken root in their hearts, I see no good for you in a life lived among those who think this way about you. I think it would be best for you to admit your guilt and through repentance save yourself from the consequences in the hereafter. You would thereby earn universal praise for two reasons: for your ability to find ways to escape, and because death in a state of grace is better than life in a state of disgrace." 5.35

Dimnah answered: "Righteous judges don't pass judgment on the basis of their own suspicions or the suspicions of others, be they dignitaries or commoners. They know that suspicion is no substitute for the truth. Even if you all suspect that I acted culpably, I know myself better than you, and my knowledge of myself is certain and is free of doubts. It is your suspicion that I slandered someone else that disgraces me in your minds. How then could I plead my own defense if I falsely slandered my own self and handed myself over to death in spite of knowing about my innocence? No life is more sacred to me than my own and no one else has a stronger claim on me. If I had done this to any of you, near or far, it would have accorded with neither my religion nor my mind and character. Therefore, refrain from speaking as you did. If you said it sincerely, it was misguided; if you said it with ulterior motives, deception and guile have no place in the character of the righteous. I know the truth of your words, but mischievous liars will construe them wrongly. I fear that your words will become a heavy burden for you. With the soldiers and the king, you've always enjoyed a reputation for good judgment and just decisions, but that has changed in my case. You've always acted in accordance with a judge's obligation to refrain from people's errors and deceptions, yet in my case you've turned to acting on suspicions at complete variance with the facts. Haven't you heard what the sages said—that someone who claims to know what he doesn't know and attests to what he has never seen will suffer the fate of the falconer who slandered his master's wife, alleging that he had seen her fornicating with a man and doing what ought not to be done?" 5.36

"And what was his fate?" asked the judge.

5.37

The Wife, the Falconer, and the Parrots

And Dimnah told the following tale: They say that in a certain city there lived a distinguished man whose wife was of noble descent, beautiful, intelligent, and chaste. The man had a falconer whom he valued for his skill in training and handling hawks. The falconer had made advances to his master's wife but had been rebuffed, so he decided to defame her. He spread many rumors, none of which were taken seriously. When he saw the failure of his attempts to expose her to scandal, he devised a malicious stratagem to disgrace her. He went out hunting one morning and trapped two fledgling parrots, which he raised separately. He taught one of them to slander his master's wife by saying, "I saw the doorkeeper lie with my mistress on my master's bed." He taught the other to say, "As for me, I won't say anything!" The fledglings, after six months' training, had mastered what he wanted them to say—they said it in the language of Balkh. He then set them before his master and they cried out. His master liked the sweetness of their voices, although he didn't understand what they were saying, as they had been taught to speak the language of Balkh, which was the language neither of the master nor of his compatriots. He took the birds from the falconer, whom he rewarded with gifts, delighted as he was, and ordered his wife to keep the birds and care for them, which she did.

5.38

Sometime later, he invited visiting dignitaries from Balkh to his home, served them fine food, and gave them wine and such other items as one offers one's guests. When they took their places to drink, the man, who was a military governor, ordered the parrots to be brought. They were set before him and cried out the phrases they had been taught. The guests, who understood what they said, looked at each another and hung their heads in embarrassment.

"Do you know what the parrots are saying?" asked one of them.

"No," he replied, "but I like their voices."

"We know what they are saying," the guests said.

The guests were embarrassed, but their host insisted they tell him. Finally, a guest told him, "One is saying, 'I saw the doorkeeper lie with my mistress on my master's bed.' The other is saying, 'As for me, I won't say anything!' It's not our custom, Governor, to eat in a house where there is fornication."

The governor was shocked to hear the guests' words. The falconer, who heard what they were saying, said, "I, too, testify to what the parrots testified."

5.39 Since the accounts agreed, the governor ordered that his wife be executed.

To this, the wife said, "Putting me to death without an investigation is likely to cause you even greater trouble. Look into the matter. Ask the parrots to say something else in this language. If they can say anything other than these two sentences, go ahead and do as you intend. If, on the other hand, that is all they can say, everyone here, including you, should know that they were trained by the deceiver who tried to seduce me to commit such a shameful deed."

5.40 The governor asked the visitors to question the parrots, and it turned out that they couldn't say anything but those two sentences in that language. The governor summoned the falconer, who entered confidently with a hawk on his arm, not at all like someone guilty or under suspicion. The wife called out from behind the curtain, "You villain! Did you see me do the foul deed you taught the parrots to describe?"

"I was asked," he replied, "and I said what I saw."

The hawk then leapt from his arm, grabbed his eyes with its talons, and tore them out.

"This," said the wife, "is God's punishment for bearing witness to something you didn't see."

Dimnah said, "I've told this story to impress on you the bitter consequences of false testimony in this world and the next."

5.41 The judge said, "A just judge needs to know the actions of those who do good in order to requite them for their deeds, and the actions of those who do evil to requite them for their misdeeds. If he deals correctly with both, those who do good will be more eager to do good and those who do evil will be more inclined to avoid evil. Alas, Dimnah, I think you had better consider the dire situation you are in and the sin you have fallen into. Repent, and confess the truth. As has been said: Better someone who turns away from his sin, admits it, and confesses than someone who persists in his sin or denies it.

You will inevitably die someday, even if pardoned. Better the pains you suffer and endure as punishment for your crime than the torments of Hell, where there is no mercy, no rest, and no end to the torment."

5.42 Dimnah said, "Your Honor has spoken the truth in words befitting the righteous and God-fearing. But we also read in the scriptures: Blessed is he who is able to avoid performing with his body actions that harm his spirit. The scholars say that a wise man disregards harm to his body, but holds fast to his spirit. They also say that it is unseemly for loathsome words to be addressed to the undeserving. I despise the body and hold fast to the spirit, so I don't think I need fear the hereafter. Never have I lied in order to harm or insult anyone, and no one has ever seen me do so. How can I commit this gravest of sins, when we read in the scriptures of God's messengers: 'Do not lie or utter falsehoods'? How can a man lie about himself and say he did something he never did? The sages have said: When you are moved by intense fear or folly to ascribe to yourself a deed you did not do, you do not wrong your soul, nor do you place yourself in the hereafter among those who kill themselves.[38] I am innocent of the charges against me. If I am put to death as a result of this slander, it will do me no harm, because of the great reward I shall receive in the hereafter."

5.43 The judge wrote down everything Dimnah said and delivered it to the lion. The lion examined the report, then summoned his mother and showed it to her. After considering Dimnah's words, she said, "Your Majesty, now I'm worried more by the prospect that Dimnah, through his deceit and cleverness, may contrive to kill you or drive you from power than by his past guilt in deceiving you and slandering your minister and guest, so that you killed him, even though he was guiltless."

Her words made a deep impression on him. "Tell me who gave you the information about Dimnah, so that I can use it as evidence for putting him to death."[39]

"I am reluctant to reveal something I've been asked to conceal," she replied. "My joy over Dimnah's death will give me no pleasure if I remember that I played a part in it by revealing secrets, something the sages have forbidden. However, I will ask the person who entrusted the information to me to allow me to name him or to inform you himself about what he heard."

She left and sent a message to the leopard. She reminded him of his responsibility to enhance the lion's prestige and of his duty to treat him well and guide him to the truth by delivering testimony that should not be concealed by someone like him. Both of them had a duty to side with the victim of injustice and exonerate a righteous person in life and in death. As the sages had said: Whoever conceals a dead man's vindication will fail to vindicate himself on the Day of Resurrection. Finally, after much persuasion, the leopard stood up and testified to what he had heard: that Dimnah, faced with Kalīlah's rebuke, had acknowledged coming between the lion and the ox. **5.44**

After the leopard testified to what he had heard Dimnah say, the prisoner who had heard Kalīlah admonishing Dimnah on the night of his prison visit and Dimnah's admission sent a message that he had testimony to give. They brought him out of prison, and he testified to what he had heard: that Dimnah, confronted with Kalīlah's rebuke, had acknowledged using slander and falsehood to come between the lion and the ox. **5.45**

"What," asked the lion, "kept the two of you from testifying when you knew we had ordered an investigation into Dimnah's case?"

Each answered, "The testimony of a single witness wouldn't have brought about a conviction. Neither of us knew of the other's testimony, so we were reluctant to speak to no avail." **5.46**

The lion was satisfied with their answer. On his orders, Dimnah was put to a most horrible death.

Here ends the Chapter on the Investigation of Dimnah. Such are the consequences of wrongdoing and the effects of envy and lying.